sleeping Shiva. Parasurama, furious, tried to force his way in, but found Ganesh a determined opponent.' (My eyes widened in excitement at this part.) 'Ganesh picked Parasurama up with his long trunk, swung him round and round till he was dizzy and helpless, and threw him to the ground. When his head cleared, Parasurama flung his axe at the obstinate Ganesh. Now Ganesh could have easily avoided the axe, but he recognised the weapon as one of Shiva's. He could not insult his father by resisting his weapon. So he took the axe humbly upon his tusk.' Ever since, Ganesh has been depicted with only one full tusk, the other half-amputated by the axe.

The thrill of that story did not diminish for me when I learned the more prosaic version which says that Ganesh wore down one tusk to a stub by using it to write down the epic verse of the *Mahabharata*. For this reason, the missing tusk signifies knowledge. As I grew older, I learned of more such symbols associated with Ganesh. Scholars of Hinduism tell us that Ganesh's fat body represents the hugeness of the cosmos, its combination of man and pachyderm signifying the unity of the microcosm (man) with the macrocosm (depicted as an elephant). Some suggest it has the less esoteric purpose of demonstrating that appearances mean little, and that an outwardly unattractive form can hide internal spiritual beauty. In any case, his looks do not prevent Ganesh, in most popular depictions, from being surrounded by beautiful women, including his twin wives, Siddhi and Buddhi. Siddhi represents spiritual power and Buddhi intellect; in some versions there is a third wife, Riddhi, embodying prosperity (though she usually replaces Buddhi—perhaps making the point that you can have either brains or wealth but not both!) Further, Ganesh's trunk can be curled into the symbol 'Om', the primal sound; and the snake found coiled around his waist represents the force of cosmic energy.

'But Ammamma,' I would ask my grandmother, 'why does Ganesh ride a rat?' For in most of the pictures in our prayer room, the deity is shown on this unusual mount. At the simplest level the sight of an elephantine god on a tiny mouse visually equates the importance of the greatest and smallest of God's creatures. And, as my grandmother explained, each animal is a symbol of Ganesh's capacities: 'like an